them others on both sides of the embankment and getting crushed in the melee.

All that the injured Sunita Devi, 54, of Amausi village in Hathras, remembers is people rushing in a panic after Bhole Baba left. "Suddenly, the crowd pushed me and I fell. People walked all over me. Suffocated, I lost consciousness," she says. Maya Devi, 70, of Navi Pur village, who also escaped with an injury to the hand, says, "I have attended half a dozen such events by Babaji. It has never happened before." She recalls there being some police presence and the overwhelming crowd. "The ground was wet due to the rain, and slippery."

THE MAN BEHIND THE GODMAN

Once a cop who claims to have worked with the local intelligence unit for 18 years in that avatar, Suraj Pal's metamorphosis into Bhole Baba followed the trajectory of most self-styled godmen, on the back of a 'divine calling' (see *Who is Bhole Baba?*). It was enough for him to seek voluntary retirement in 1990, move into a hut in his village Bahadur Garh in Kasganj tehsil, and embark on a spiritual journey.

Soon, thousands began flocking to his sermons, swayed by his simplistic messages of "equality, humanity and truth", which 52-year-old Sita Devi of Aligarh says explain his vast following among women like her. As his influence grew, so did his entourage. The 'Narayani Sena', his army of volunteers clad in light pink shirts, trousers and white caps, started managing traffic and other arrangements for his events. He also began expanding his reach via social media, running a YouTube channel with 31k subscribers and a Facebook page. Traditional media, though, is kept out of his *satsangs*.

The godman did run afoul of the law in 2000, when he and six others were arrested in Agra under the Drugs and Magic Remedies Act but acquitted for lack of evidence. He got into trouble in 2022 too, when he sought permission for a small *satsang* in Farrukhabad district, where 50,000 people turned up, against the Covid protocol of 50.

A TRAGEDY FORETOLD



ARUN KUMAR

- Permission granted for 80,000 but **over 200,000 attend** the event
- Lax security management at the venue. **Very few police vehicles** were present
- **No proper queue system** for entry or exit, leading to the mad crush after the godman's exit
- **Rescue operation slow**, allege several eyewitnesses

THE ACTION TAKEN

The godman himself has not been seen or heard of since the incident. Police have been deployed outside his 13-acre ashram, the Ram Kutir Charitable Trust, in Mainpuri since the day of incident. Bhole Baba may well be elsewhere but the officials say they are on vigil for the safety of his followers inside the ashram after the Hathras incident. Bhole Baba's lawyer A.P. Singh released a statement claiming that "anti-social elements" had orchestrated the stampede as part of a conspiracy.

Strangely enough, the baba's name does not figure in the FIR lodged for the incident. That has been registered against '*mukhya sevadar*' (chief organiser) Devprakash Madhukar and other organisers under Sections 105 (culpable homicide not amounting to murder), 110 (attempt to commit culpable homicide), 126 (2) (wrongful restraint), 223 (disobedience to order duly promulgated by the public servant) and 238 (causing disappearance of evidence) of the newly-implemented Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. A police officer, speaking on condition of anonymity, says no government will touch the godman, for fear of offending his massive flock—especially among Dalits, a significant vote bank for all parties.

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, though, indicated otherwise while addressing the media soon after the incident. All those responsible for the Hathras accident would be brought to book, he emphasised. Asked why Bhole Baba had been left out of the FIR, he said the initial FIR is against those who sought permission for the event, and subsequent investigation will cover all responsible. The CM also clarified that the *sevadars* managed the internal arrangements, the administration provided the police arrangements outside. The *sevadars*, he also added, fled immediately after the incident instead of arranging transport for the injured.

Yogi has also constituted a special investigation team under the chairpersonship of Anupam Kulsreshtha, the additional director general of police, Agra. The UP government has also initiated a judicial inquiry, to be led by a retired high court judge, which will include retired senior officials from the administration and police. Meanwhile, the central and state governments have announced Rs 4 lakh compensation to the families of the deceased and another Rs 1 lakh to the injured.

But there are no real answers yet on Bhole Baba's whereabouts, or why his name is missing in the FIR. Ditto for the action taken against the officials who granted permission for the event. Calls to UP Police DGP Prashant Kumar and SP Hathras Nipun Agarwal went unanswered. For a CM who prides himself on his tough image as Bulldozer Baba, it is imperative that his government allows no one to perceive laxity vis-à-vis Bhole Baba. ■